

out with Elliott and talking a mile a minute with each other the way they usually did, each of them was in his own world. As for the “feast,” Meredith and Mitchell had called a caterer, and Meredith, who had clearly never entertained guests in her entire life, was stressing about how to reheat the food she’d ordered. Linda stepped in and tried to help, but when she tried to initiate conversation, she came to the sudden realization that she had absolutely nothing in common with this younger, superficial woman. Linda and I later agreed dinner wasn’t the only thing that year that was tasteless.

After dinner, I wandered to the picture window and looked out on the backyard. A cold drizzle fell against the windowpane, making the situation inside even more depressing. The flowers Judy usually tended were dead in their beds. I looked again at Mitchell, who had huge, dark bags under his eyes. He said he was happy, but it was obvious the guy was a wreck. Despite the rain, Mitchell and I stepped outside for a moment and he proceeded to tell me how this had been the worst year of his life, that he’d made some serious errors in judgment and that, in the process, he’d lost everything he ever cared for—namely, his family. “I wanted to call and warn you that Judy wasn’t going to be here,” he said. “But it was all just so difficult and I couldn’t find the words. Kevin,” he said with one hand on my shoulder, “what have I done?”

I had no idea what to say to my friend. I couldn’t believe my eyes. I couldn’t believe that in a few short months such a wonderful family could be so unceremoniously dismantled. “I’m sorry” was all I could manage.

I’m not proud to say this, but we got out of there as fast as we could. The warm, wonderful Thanksgiving tradition we had always shared with the Claytons had ended, cold turkey. “That was awful,” Trevor said on the drive home.

“I miss Elise,” Savannah said. “And Judy.” Nobody disagreed.

And then the kids started talking about all the things Judy had done, every year, to make Thanksgiving so special—the food, the decorations, the toast “to family” where we held our glasses aloft. It was sad and unnatural not to have her there. The value she added to their family was tremendous; it wasn’t the same without her. When